

Figure 3.10 *Shahr-i Zohak (fifth–thirteenth century), general view, crenellated tower and walls. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

in Ghur the decorations were pressed, incised into or molded from wet plaster, while in Bamiyan they were made out of the brickwork itself (Figure 3.10). As has been noted for the architectural remains in central through southern Ghur, in the Bamiyan region also, the degree and complexity of exterior surface decoration underscored the possibility of non-defensive functions, at least for some phases of the structures' existences.[48]

The Bamiyan structures' seemingly better state of preservation – or perhaps, simply more available documentation – than their Ghuri counterparts permits a clearer understanding of interior spaces as well: the non-intersecting vaults and elliptical domes (Figure 3.11) are indicative of pre-Islamic Central Asian building practices.[49] Finally, *in situ* interior mural paintings were documented particularly in the structures dotting the routes of access to the west of Bamiyan (Figure 3.18).[50] Altogether, these data help to identify an architectural culture with minor regional variations encompassing large swathes of Afghanistan during the pre-Islamic